UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 8 — Part B
Technique, Method and Methodology

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Research methods in anthropology: ... (b) Distinction between technique, method and methodology" — with the approaches to inquiry the papers attach to it.

THE OPENING STORY

In 1926 Robert Redfield studied Tepoztlán, a village in Mexico, and described a harmonious, well-integrated community. In 1943 Oscar Lewis went to the same village and found suspicion, envy and conflict. Same place, two pictures. Asked about it, Redfield is said to have suggested that he had asked "what do these people enjoy?" while Lewis had asked "what do they suffer from?" — and Lewis had added surveys, household budgets and psychological tests to his observation. **The difference was not the village. It was the methodology.**

What this topic is really about. Three words students mix up. A **technique** is a specific tool for collecting data (an interview schedule, a genealogy chart). A **method** is a strategy that organises techniques (participant observation, the case-study method, the comparative method). A **methodology** is the philosophy behind the choice — what counts as knowledge and how it can be known (positivism, interpretivism, phenomenology). The papers then ask about the big methodological positions: **positivist and non-positivist** approaches, **subjectivity**, **phenomenology**, and **mixed methods**.

Study window	Opens 13 Nov 2026 — **half a day** (one session), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	2 hr first pass, including the 20-mark mixed-methods answer
Revision time	14 min full note • 5 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Two units — **the three-level distinction** (with one worked example) and **the methodological positions** (positivist vs interpretive, subjectivity, phenomenology, mixed methods). Learn Fig. 1 and Fig. 3 cold.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	Fieldwork history and ethics are **8-A**. The individual tools — observation, interview, schedule, genealogy, case study — are **8-C**. Sampling and analysis are **8-D**.

Candid verdict — few direct askings, but the latest is a 20-marker. The exact syllabus phrase was asked four times, all before 1995 (1986, 1987, 1990, 1993). Since then the papers have asked about **methodology itself**: **2006** (subjectivity in research), **2007** (positivist and non-positivist approaches), **2019** (phenomenology as a research method, 15) and **2026** (the mixed-method approach, 20). The 2025 question on anthropology as a bridge between science and humanities (20) also needs this material. Your tracker shows PYQ Count 16 — a Topic 8 total; this sub-topic's own count is **4**. With 15- and 20-markers in 2019 and 2026, Mains Value **High** stands. Use the three-level distinction to open every answer here, then spend the marks on the positions.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **The distinction** — technique, method, methodology; with research design and paradigm placed above them.
- **One worked example** — Malinowski's Trobriand research read at all three levels.
- **Positivist and non-positivist approaches** (2007) — Comte, Durkheim, Radcliffe-Brown, Murdock against Weber, Boas, Evans-Pritchard, Geertz.
- **Subjectivity and objectivity** (2006) — the observer problem, Redfield–Lewis, Mead–Freeman, reflexivity, triangulation.
- **Phenomenology** (2019) — Husserl, Schutz, Merleau-Ponty; Jackson, Csordas, Stoller, Kleinman.
- **Mixed methods** (2026) — designs, triangulation, anthropological and Indian examples.
- **Qualitative and quantitative; inductive and deductive; emic and etic** as methodological pairs.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
History of fieldwork; Malinowski's method in full; ethics	8-A, done	Used here only as an example
Each tool in detail — observation types, interview types, schedule vs questionnaire, genealogy, case study, PRA	8-C	Techniques named here; detail there
Sampling; coding; statistics; presentation	8-D	After collection
Interpretive and postmodern theory as theory	6-H, 6-J, done	Their methodological side only

How it connects outward

- **7-A** — emic and etic began as Pike's methodological pair (2015).
- **6-G and 6-H** — Harris's etic, behavioural strategy against Geertz's interpretive search for meaning: the positivist/interpretive split in theory.
- **8-A** — the 2024 challenges question and 2026 ethics note both turn on methodology.
- **Topic 1** — the 2025 question on anthropology bridging science and humanities (20) is a methodology question.

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

1995–2021 wording from your compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 8) and Edukemy lists; 2019 marks from your compilation; 2025 and 2026 from published papers. Marks not recorded for 2006 and 2007.

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2026	Discuss the mixed method approach in anthropological research.	Designs, rationale, examples, limits	20
2019	Discuss phenomenology as a research method in anthropological studies.	Husserl → anthropology; critique	15
2007	Critically examine the contribution of positivistic and non-positivistic approaches in social science research.	Two methodologies, critically	—
2006	Critically examine the role of subjectivity in anthropological research.	Objectivity problem; remedies	—

Before 1995 (not counted) — the exact syllabus phrase

Year	Question
1993	Write a note on method and methodology.
1990	Discuss the difference between technique, method and methodology as employed in anthropological studies.
1987	Distinguish between technique, method and methodology. Examine their role in anthropological studies.
1986	Trace the rise and development of empiricism in anthropology.

Adjacent (not counted)

- **2025** — anthropology as a bridge between science and humanities (20): positivist vs interpretive.
- **2015** — emic and etic from the study of language (10): counted in 7-A.
- **2010, 2024** — sampling techniques (30; 15): counted in 8-D.

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper; GS Prelims has not tested this content.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
The three-level distinction	3 pre-1995	Clean definitions plus one example carried through all three levels	5.1–5.2 + Fig. 1. Master Answer 4
Methodological positions	2 — 2006, 2007 (+2025)	Positivist vs interpretive, objectivity vs subjectivity, with anthropologists	5.3–5.4 + Fig. 2. Master Answer 3
Named approaches	2 — 2019, 2026	Phenomenology and mixed methods: what, how, examples, limits	5.5–5.6 + Fig. 3. Master Answers 1–2

Trend reading

- **From "distinguish" to "discuss an approach".** The exact phrase has not been set since 1993; recent stems name an approach — phenomenology (2019), mixed methods (2026).
- **Next likely:** grounded theory, triangulation, qualitative vs quantitative, reflexivity, or a return of the distinction as a 10-mark note.
- **Mains Value: High** — two of the last eight years carried a 15- or 20-marker.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — Three levels, top to bottom. A paradigm (a world-view of knowledge) shapes a **methodology** (the logic of inquiry), which justifies a **method** (a strategy), which uses **techniques** (tools) to produce data. *Fig. 1*

MOVE 2 — Two great methodologies. **Positivism**: the social world can be studied like nature, for causal laws, with objective, often quantitative evidence. **Interpretivism**: social life is meaningful action, to be understood from within. *Fig. 2*

MOVE 3 — The observer cannot be removed. Subjectivity enters every field study (Redfield–Lewis, Mead–Freeman); the answer is not pretending to objectivity but reflexivity and triangulation.

MOVE 4 — Phenomenology starts from experience. Bracket assumptions, describe the lived world, attend to the body — Husserl and Merleau-Ponty brought into anthropology by Jackson, Csordas and Stoller.

MOVE 5 — Mixed methods combine strengths. Numbers for breadth and pattern, ethnography for depth and meaning, integrated by design and checked by triangulation. *Fig. 3*

That chain is the shape of any answer: **three levels → two methodologies → the observer → experience → integration.**

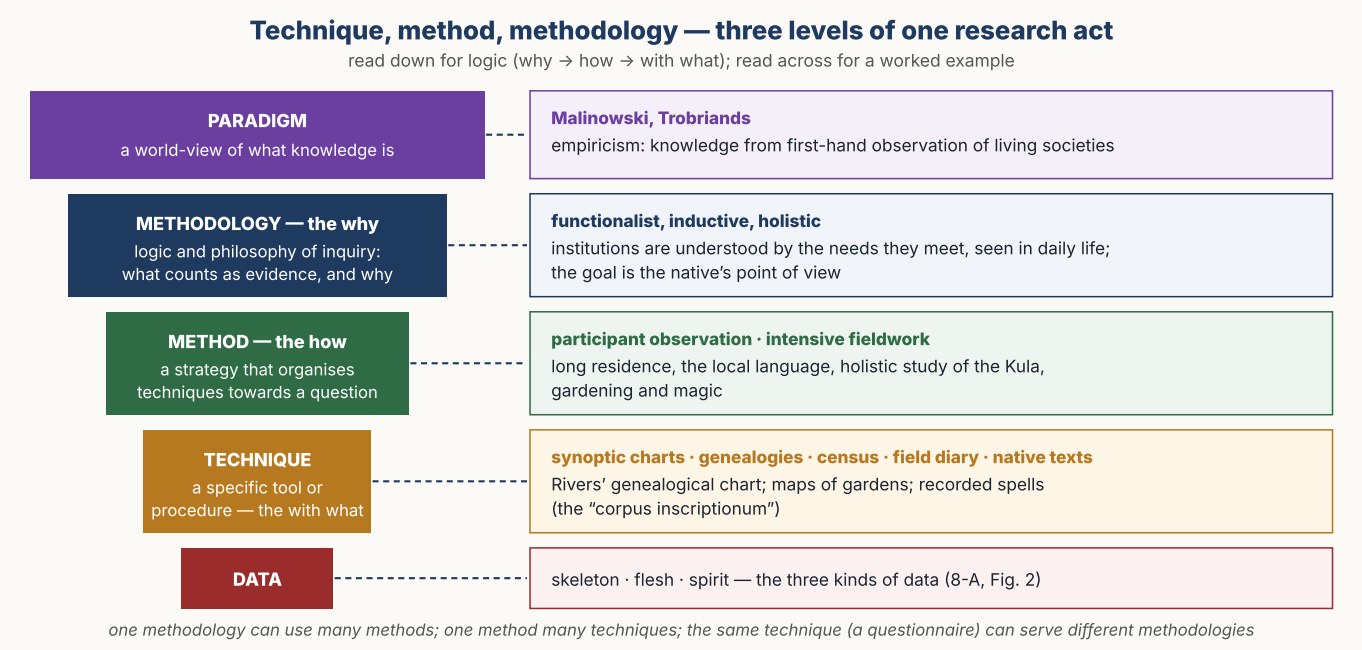


Fig. 1 — the hero diagram. The narrowing pyramid shows the logical order; the right-hand column carries Malinowski's Trobriand research through every level. Draw both halves for any "distinguish" question.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 The distinction

STORY HOOK

*Think of cooking. The **technique** is how you chop or temper; the **method** is the recipe that orders those techniques into a dish; the **methodology** is your theory of good food — why this dish, and how you would know it is good.*

Why it helps: a homely analogy that keeps the three levels apart under exam pressure.

Level	Definition	Question it answers	Anthropological examples
Technique	A specific, concrete procedure or tool for collecting or recording data	With what?	Interview schedule, questionnaire, genealogy chart, map, photograph, pile sort, free list
Method	A systematic strategy of inquiry that combines techniques to answer a research question	How?	Participant observation, case-study method, genealogical method, comparative method, survey method
Methodology	The logic and philosophy of inquiry — the principles that justify which methods are chosen and what counts as valid knowledge	Why, and how do we know?	Positivism, interpretivism, phenomenology, critical theory, mixed-methods pragmatism

- **Above methodology** sit **paradigm** (Kuhn, 1962: a shared framework of assumptions) and the questions of **ontology** (what social reality is) and **epistemology** (how it can be known).
- **Research design** is the plan that puts methodology into practice: problem, hypotheses or questions, sampling, methods, analysis.
- **The relation is hierarchical but not one-to-one.** One methodology may use several methods; one method many techniques; and the same technique — a questionnaire — can serve a positivist survey or an interpretive study.
- **Pelto & Pelto,** *Anthropological Research: The Structure of Inquiry* (1970; 2nd ed. 1978), is the standard anthropological statement; H. Russell Bernard, *Research Methods in Anthropology* (1988 onwards), the standard

manual.

> **The line that lifts a distinction answer.** "Technique answers 'with what?', method 'how?', and methodology 'why, and how do we know?' — and a good study is consistent across all three."

5.2 Methodological pairs

Pair	First	Second
Inductive / deductive	From observations to generalisation (most fieldwork)	From theory to hypothesis to test (cross-cultural surveys)
Qualitative / quantitative	Meaning, depth, words, small samples	Measurement, breadth, numbers, statistics
Emic / etic	Insider categories (Pike 1954)	Observer's comparative categories
Idiographic / nomothetic	The particular case (Windelband 1894)	General laws
Holistic / analytic	The whole community	Selected variables

5.3 Positivist and non-positivist approaches — the 2007 question

STORY HOOK

Evans-Pritchard lived among the Azande and ran his household by consulting their poison oracle, as they did. He later wrote that he found it as satisfactory a way of managing his affairs as any he knew. He did not believe in witchcraft — but he had learnt it from the inside.

Why it helps: interpretive understanding (Weber's *Verstehen*) in one memorable act.

Two methodologies — explain or understand?

POSITIVIST — explain

Reality: objective, exists apart from the observer

Aim: causal explanation; general laws (nomothetic)

Logic: deductive; hypothesis and test

Data: measurable, often quantitative

Observer: neutral, value-free

View: etic

Comte (1830s) · Durkheim, Rules 1895: social facts as things · Radcliffe-Brown, a "natural science of society" · Murdock, HRAF 1937, Social Structure 1949 · White; Harris's cultural materialism

NON-POSITIVIST / INTERPRETIVE — understand

Reality: socially constructed, meaningful

Aim: understanding meaning (idiographic)

Logic: inductive; interpretation

Data: words, symbols, actions in context

Observer: positioned, reflexive

View: emic

Dilthey · Weber: Verstehen · Boas · Evans-Pritchard, Marett Lecture 1950: anthropology belongs with the humanities · Geertz 1973: an interpretive science in search of meaning · phenomenology

Fig. 2 — positivist and interpretive methodologies on six bases, with the anthropologists on each side. Use it for 2007 and for the 2025 "science and humanities" question.

Contribution and critique

Approach	Contribution	Limits
Positivist	Rigour, replicability, comparison across cultures (HRAF), testable hypotheses, measurement — e.g., cross-cultural correlations of descent and residence	Strips context and meaning; treats people as objects; "value-free" claims hide the observer; categories may be ethnocentric
Non-positivist	Meaning, context, the actor's view; thick description; reflexivity; suits small-scale, symbolic and ritual life	Subjective, hard to verify or generalise; risk of relativism; depends on the interpreter

The resolution most anthropologists take: the two are complementary. Anthropology, as the 2025 question put it, **bridges science and the humanities** — explanation and understanding, etic and emic, numbers and meaning. Mixed methods (5.6) is the practical form of that bridge.

5.4 Subjectivity in anthropological research — the 2006 question

STORY HOOK

Redfield found Tepoztlán harmonious in 1926; Lewis found it full of conflict in 1943. Mead described carefree Samoan adolescence in 1928; Freeman, in 1983, said her informants had been joking. Two villages, four anthropologists, two very different truths.

Why it helps: the two classic restudies are the whole evidence for the subjectivity problem.

- **Where subjectivity enters:** choice of problem and site; the researcher's gender, nationality, caste, class and theory; selection of informants; what is noticed and recorded; interpretation; and writing.
- **The observer effect:** the community changes its behaviour because it is observed; informants tell the visitor what they think he wants.
- **Restudies** as evidence: Redfield and Lewis (Tepoztlán); Mead and Freeman (Samoa) — differences of period, theory, informant and temperament.
- **Subjectivity as resource:** the reflexive and experiential turn (Rosaldo 1989) treats the researcher's position and feelings as data, not noise.
- **Remedies:** reflexivity (state one's position); long residence; multiple informants; **triangulation** of data, investigators, theories and methods (Denzin 1970); team and repeat studies; member checking — returning interpretations to the community; transparent field notes.
- **Intersubjectivity:** knowledge produced between researcher and researched (Schutz), neither purely objective nor purely subjective.

5.5 Phenomenology as a research method — the 2019 question

STORY HOOK

Paul Stoller spent years apprenticed to Songhay sorcerers in Niger. His teacher told him he would learn nothing by watching and writing; he had to learn with his body — through taste, sound and smell. He called his later book The Taste of Ethnographic Things (1989).

Why it helps: phenomenology in anthropology means learning through lived, bodily experience — Stoller is the picture of it.

The philosophy

Thinker	Idea
Edmund Husserl (1900–01; 1913)	"Back to the things themselves"; **epoché** or bracketing of assumptions; the **lifeworld** (*Lebenswelt*) of everyday experience
Martin Heidegger (1927)	Being-in-the-world: we are always already involved in a world, not detached spectators
Alfred Schutz (1932)	*The Phenomenology of the Social World*: intersubjectivity; typifications; common-sense knowledge
Maurice Merleau-Ponty (1945)	*Phenomenology of Perception*: the **lived body** as the ground of perception

In anthropology

- **Michael Jackson,** *Paths Toward a Clearing* (1989) — radical empiricism; experience shared in fieldwork among the Kuranko of Sierra Leone.
- **Thomas Csordas,** "Embodiment as a Paradigm for Anthropology" (*Ethos*, 1990) — the body as the subject of culture, not its object; the 2025 note on "culture and embodiment".
- **Paul Stoller** (1987, 1989) — sensuous ethnography among the Songhay.
- **Arthur Kleinman,** *The Illness Narratives* (1988) — illness as lived experience, not only disease.
- **Pierre Bourdieu,** *Outline of a Theory of Practice* (1977) — habitus as embodied disposition.

As a method

- Bracket the researcher's categories; describe experience as it is lived.
- Participant **experience**, not only observation — learning skills, rituals and bodily techniques.

- In-depth, open interviews and narratives of experience; life histories.
- Attention to the senses, emotions, body, time and space as lived.
- **Uses:** illness and healing, pain, ritual, possession, migration, disability, caste humiliation (Gopal Guru, *Humiliation*, 2009).
- **Critique:** subjectivism; weak generalisation; neglect of structure, power and history (Marxist and structural critics); doubtful whether experience can be shared across cultures; bracketing may be impossible.

5.6 The mixed-method approach — the 2026 question

STORY HOOK

*Between 1985 and 1992 the Anthropological Survey of India's **People of India** project, led by K. S. Singh, profiled 4,635 communities. Hundreds of scholars filled the same structured schedule for every community — and wrote an ethnographic account of each.*

Why it helps: an Indian, nationwide example of numbers and narrative in one design.

- **Definition:** research that combines qualitative and quantitative data, methods and analysis within one study or programme, and **integrates** them to answer a question better than either could alone (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2007; Tashakkori & Teddlie, 1998).
- **Methodological basis:** pragmatism — choose methods by the question, not by paradigm loyalty.
- **Rationale:** triangulation (confirm), complementarity (fill gaps), development (one informs the other), initiation (contradictions reveal new questions), expansion (breadth and depth).

Designs

Design	How it works	Example
Convergent parallel	Collect both at once; compare and merge	Household survey and participant observation in one village
Explanatory sequential	Numbers first, then ethnography to explain them	Census shows tribal school drop-out; fieldwork finds why
Exploratory sequential	Ethnography first, then a survey built from it	Free-lists of illness terms → a questionnaire for the district
Embedded	One strand inside the other's main design	Interviews inside a nutrition trial

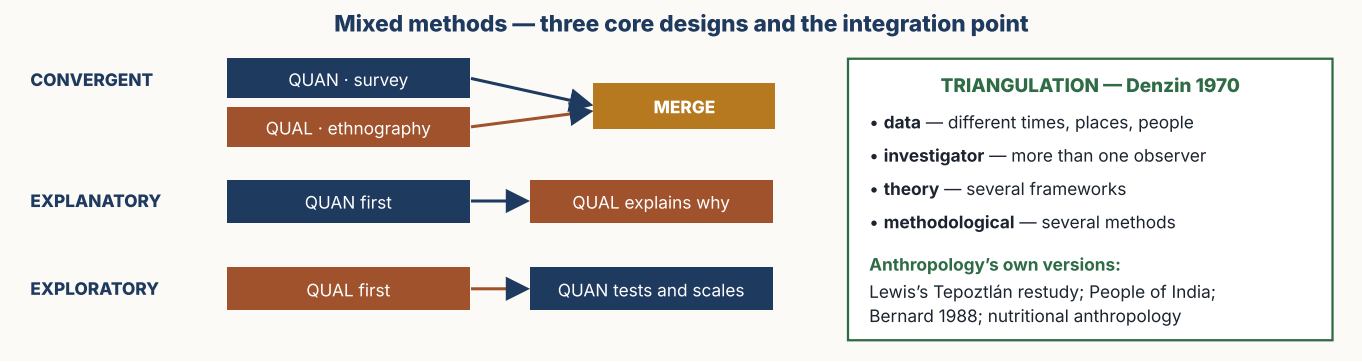


Fig. 3 — the three core designs and Denzin's four kinds of triangulation. Draw the left half and name two triangulation types for the 2026 answer.

Anthropological and Indian examples

- **Oscar Lewis's Tepoztlán** (1951) — census, household budgets, Rorschach tests and participant observation together.
- **Genealogical method** (Rivers) — counts and charts that carry qualitative kinship meaning.
- **People of India** (1985–92) — a common schedule plus ethnographic profiles for 4,635 communities.

- **Health and nutrition** — anthropometry and dietary surveys with ethnography of food beliefs (the 2025 nutritional anthropology question); NFHS data read with local fieldwork.
- **Development evaluation** — surveys of a tribal scheme combined with case studies and participatory methods (PRA).

Strengths and limits

Strengths	Limits
Breadth and depth; checks one kind of evidence against another; generalisation with meaning; suits policy	Paradigm tension (can positivism and interpretivism be combined?); needs more time, money and skills; integration is often shallow — two studies side by side; the qualitative strand may be reduced to illustration

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	Definitions of technique, method, methodology with one example each • the three questions: with what / how / why • Pelto & Pelto 1970 • positivist names (Comte, Durkheim 1895, Radcliffe-Brown, Murdock HRAF 1937) and interpretive names (Weber, Evans-Pritchard 1950, Geertz 1973) • Husserl's epoché and lifeworld; Merleau-Ponty 1945; Csordas 1990 • Creswell & Plano Clark 2007; three designs; Denzin's four triangulations • People of India 1985–92, 4,635 communities
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	Why the levels are hierarchical but not one-to-one • the six-basis positivist/interpretive table • where subjectivity enters and its remedies • phenomenology as method and its critique • why anthropology bridges science and humanities
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Windelband • Kuhn's paradigm • Heidegger, Schutz detail • Kleinman, Bourdieu, Guru on humiliation • the five mixed-methods purposes

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Redfield 1926 / Lewis 1943	Tepoztlán: harmony vs conflict	Subjectivity; mixed methods	Same village, two pictures
Pelto & Pelto 1970	*Anthropological Research: The Structure of Inquiry*	The distinction	—
Comte; Durkheim 1895	Positivism; social facts as things	2007	—
Murdock 1937 / 1949	HRAF; *Social Structure*	Positivist anthropology	—
Evans-Pritchard 1937 / 1950	Azande oracle; Marett Lecture	Interpretive turn	Running his house by oracle
Geertz 1973	Interpretive science in search of meaning	Interpretive	—
Mead 1928 / Freeman 1983	Samoa restudy	Subjectivity	Joking informants
Denzin 1970	Four triangulations	Remedy; mixed methods	—
Husserl; Merleau-Ponty 1945	Epoché, lifeworld; lived body	2019	—
Csordas 1990	Embodiment as paradigm	2019; 2025 note	—
Stoller 1989	*The Taste of Ethnographic Things*	2019	Learning sorcery by the body

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Creswell & Plano Clark 2007	Mixed-methods designs	2026	—
People of India 1985–92	K. S. Singh; 4,635 communities	2026, India	One schedule, 4,635 profiles

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Technique	A specific data-collection tool	Distinction	"The genealogy chart is a technique."
Method	A strategy that organises techniques	Distinction	"Participant observation is a method."
Methodology	The logic and philosophy of inquiry	Distinction	"Positivism is a methodology."
Paradigm	A shared framework of assumptions	Above methodology	"Kuhn's paradigm sits above methodology."
Ontology	What social reality is	Positivism	"Positivist ontology assumes an objective world."
Epistemology	How reality can be known	Positivism	"Interpretive epistemology rests on understanding."
Verstehen	Interpretive understanding of meaning	2007	"Evans-Pritchard practised Verstehen among the Azande."
Nomothetic / idiographic	Law-seeking / case-describing	2007	"HRAF is nomothetic; the monograph idiographic."
Reflexivity	Examining one's own influence	2006	"Reflexivity turns bias into data."
Triangulation	Cross-checking with several sources or methods	2006, 2026	"Triangulation guards against a single informant."
Epoché	Bracketing one's assumptions	2019	"Epoché asks the researcher to suspend judgement."
Lifeworld	The world of everyday lived experience	2019	"Phenomenology studies the lifeworld."
Embodiment	Experience grounded in the body	2019, 2025	"Csordas made embodiment a paradigm."
Mixed methods	Integrating qualitative and quantitative	2026	"Mixed methods joins breadth to depth."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Technique:** a specific, concrete procedure or tool for collecting or recording data.
- **Method:** a systematic strategy of inquiry that combines techniques to answer a research question.
- **Methodology:** the logic and philosophy of inquiry — the principles that justify the choice of methods and define what counts as valid knowledge.
- **Mixed methods:** research that combines and integrates qualitative and quantitative data and methods to answer a question better than either alone.

Exam-ready opening hooks

- (Distinction / subjectivity) “Redfield found Tepoztlán harmonious; Lewis, in the same village, found conflict. The difference lay not in the village but in methodology.”
- (Positivism) “Evans-Pritchard ran his household by the Azande poison oracle — the best illustration that anthropology must understand before it explains.”
- (Phenomenology) “Stoller’s Songhay teacher told him to stop watching and start tasting: phenomenology asks the anthropologist to learn through lived experience.”
- (Mixed methods) “The People of India project profiled 4,635 communities with one schedule and one ethnography each — numbers and narrative in a single design.”

Analytical and transition lines

- “Technique answers ‘with what?’, method ‘how?’, methodology ‘why, and how do we know?’.”
- “The same questionnaire can serve a positivist survey or an interpretive study; methodology decides how it is read.”
- “Subjectivity cannot be removed from fieldwork, only acknowledged and checked.”

Conclusions

- “Anthropology bridges science and the humanities: it explains and it understands, and its best work does both.”
- “Mixed methods is the practical form of that bridge — provided the strands are genuinely integrated.”

India linkages

- People of India (K. S. Singh, 1985–92) • Census with ethnography • NFHS with fieldwork • PRA in tribal development • Gopal Guru on humiliation (2009) as phenomenology of caste.

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — three levels	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	Any distinction question	A narrowing pyramid: paradigm → methodology → method → technique → data, with Malinowski’s research beside each
Fig. 2 — two methodologies	Draw for 2007, 2025	Positivism; science vs humanities	Two columns, six bases, names under each
Fig. 3 — mixed designs	Draw for 2026	Mixed methods	Three rows: convergent (merge), explanatory (quan → qual), exploratory (qual → quan)

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Qualitative against quantitative

Basis	Qualitative	Quantitative
Aim	Meaning, process, context	Measurement, pattern, cause
Data	Words, observations, texts	Numbers, counts, scales
Sample	Small, purposive	Large, often random
Typical tools	Participant observation, open interview, life history	Survey, schedule, census, anthropometry
Strength / weakness	Depth / hard to generalise	Breadth / thin on meaning

11.2 Method against methodology — the most-confused pair

Basis	Method	Methodology
Nature	Practical procedure	Philosophical justification
Question	How to collect?	Why this way, and is it valid?
Example	Participant observation	Interpretivism that values it
Changes when	The field demands it	The theory of knowledge changes

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (20 marks). "Discuss the mixed method approach in anthropological research." (2026)

When Oscar Lewis restudied Tepoztlán in 1943, he added a census, household budgets and Rorschach tests to participant observation — and found a village far less harmonious than Redfield's. Combining kinds of evidence changed the picture. That is the case for **mixed methods**: research that combines qualitative and quantitative data and methods within one study and **integrates** them to answer a question better than either could alone (Creswell and Plano Clark 2007).

Basis. Its methodology is pragmatism — choose methods by the question, not by loyalty to positivism or interpretivism. Anthropology, which bridges science and the humanities, has long practised it: Rivers' genealogies were both counts and kinship meanings; Malinowski's synoptic charts sat beside his diary.

Purposes. Triangulation, to confirm findings; complementarity, to fill gaps; development, where one strand builds the other; and expansion, adding breadth to depth. Denzin (1970) named four triangulations — of data, investigators, theories and methods.

Designs. In a **convergent** design, survey and ethnography run together and are merged. In an **explanatory sequential** design, numbers come first and fieldwork explains them — a census shows tribal drop-out, interviews find why. In an **exploratory sequential** design, fieldwork comes first and builds a survey — free-lists of local illness terms become a district questionnaire. An **embedded** design places one strand inside the other. *[Draw Fig. 3.]*

Examples. The Anthropological Survey of India's People of India project (1985–92) used one schedule and one ethnographic profile for each of 4,635 communities. Nutritional anthropology joins anthropometry and dietary surveys to the ethnography of food; development evaluation joins surveys to case studies and PRA.

Limits. Paradigms may conflict; mixed designs need more time, money and skills; integration is often shallow, two studies side by side; and the qualitative strand may shrink into illustration.

Used with real integration, mixed methods is the practical form of anthropology's double nature — explaining patterns and understanding meanings in the same study.

About 380 words. The designs and one Indian example are what lift it above 12.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (15 marks). "Discuss phenomenology as a research method in anthropological studies." (2019)

Phenomenology studies experience as it is lived. Husserl asked philosophy to go "back to the things themselves", to **bracket** (epoché) prior assumptions and describe the **lifeworld** of everyday experience; Heidegger stressed being-in-the-world, Schutz the intersubjective common sense of social life (1932), and Merleau-Ponty the **lived body** as the ground of perception (1945).

In anthropology. Michael Jackson's radical empiricism (*Paths Toward a Clearing*, 1989) grounded knowledge in experience shared with the Kuranko. Thomas Csordas proposed **embodiment as a paradigm** (1990): the body as the subject of culture. Paul Stoller, apprenticed to Songhay sorcerers, learnt through taste, sound and smell (1989). Kleinman's *Illness Narratives* (1988) treated illness as lived suffering.

As a method it asks the researcher to suspend categories; to learn through participant **experience** — skills, rituals, bodily techniques — as well as observation; to use open interviews and life narratives; and to attend to

senses, emotions, time and space. It suits illness and healing, pain, possession, migration and disability; Gopal Guru's work on humiliation (2009) applies it to caste.

Critique. It risks subjectivism and weak generalisation; it can neglect structure, power and history; bracketing may be impossible; and whether experience can be shared across cultures is doubtful.

Phenomenology does not replace other methods but deepens them, restoring the lived, embodied person to anthropological knowledge.

About 280 words.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (15 marks) — skeleton. "Critically examine the contribution of positivist and non-positivist approaches in social science research." (2007) — also serves 2006 and 2025.

- **Open:** Evans-Pritchard and the poison oracle — understanding before explanation.
- **Positivist:** Comte; Durkheim (1895); Radcliffe-Brown's natural science of society; Murdock's HRAF (1937) — contribution: rigour, comparison, testable hypotheses; limits: context and meaning lost, false neutrality.
- **Non-positivist:** Weber's Verstehen; Boas; Evans-Pritchard's Marett Lecture (1950); Geertz (1973); phenomenology — contribution: meaning, actor's view, reflexivity; limits: subjectivity, weak generalisation.
- **Draw:** Fig. 2.
- **Subjectivity:** Redfield–Lewis, Mead–Freeman; remedies — reflexivity, triangulation (Denzin 1970).
- **Close:** complementary; anthropology bridges science and humanities; mixed methods as the practical bridge.

MASTER ANSWER 4 (10 marks, about 150 words). "Distinguish between technique, method and methodology." (1987; 1990; 1993-type note)

A **technique** is a specific tool or procedure for collecting or recording data — an interview schedule, a genealogy chart, a map. A **method** is a systematic strategy that organises techniques to answer a question — participant observation, the case-study method, the comparative method. A **methodology** is the logic and philosophy of inquiry that justifies the choice of methods and defines valid knowledge — positivism, interpretivism, phenomenology.

Technique asks "with what?", method "how?", methodology "why, and how do we know?". In Malinowski's Trobriand study, the methodology was functionalist empiricism; the method, intensive participant observation; the techniques, synoptic charts, genealogies, a field diary and recorded native texts.

The levels are hierarchical but not one-to-one: one methodology may use many methods, and one technique can serve different methodologies (Pelto and Pelto 1970).

About 150 words. Draw Fig. 1's pyramid in the margin.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Distinguish between technique, method and methodology.	10	H R D S
2	Triangulation in anthropological research.	10	R S
3	Reflexivity.	10	S
4	Qualitative and quantitative research.	10	R
5	Culture and embodiment.	10	H S
6	Critically examine the role of subjectivity in anthropological research.	15	H R S
7	Discuss phenomenology as a research method in anthropology.	15	H R S I
8	Critically examine positivist and non-positivist approaches in social research.	15	H R D S

#	Question	Marks	Tags
9	“Anthropology bridges science and the humanities.” Elucidate with reference to methodology.	20	H D S
10	Discuss the mixed method approach in anthropological research.	20	H R D S I
11	What can restudies such as Redfield–Lewis and Mead–Freeman teach about method?	15	S
12	Trace the rise of empiricism in anthropology.	15	H S

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)

- Define technique, method, methodology with one example each.
- The three questions they answer.
- Positivist vs interpretive on six bases.
- Husserl’s epoché and lifeworld; Merleau-Ponty’s lived body.
- Mixed methods: definition and three designs.

Factual anchors (5)

- Pelto & Pelto — title and year.
- Four positivist and four interpretive names.
- Two restudies with years and findings.
- Denzin’s four triangulations.
- People of India — leader, years, number.

Comparisons (3)

- Qualitative vs quantitative.
- Method vs methodology.
- Malinowski at all three levels.

Critical judgement (2)

- Five remedies for subjectivity.
- Four limits of mixed methods.

Diagram reproduction (2)

- Draw Fig. 1’s pyramid with the Malinowski column.
- Draw Fig. 3’s three designs.

Story recall (1)

- Tell each hook in one line: Tepoztlán twice, the cooking analogy, the poison oracle, Samoa twice, Stoller’s taste, People of India.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

Three levels — paradigm → **methodology** (why; logic of inquiry) → **method** (how; strategy) → **technique** (with what; tool) → data (Pelto & Pelto 1970) → **two methodologies** — positivist explain (Comte, Durkheim, Radcliffe-Brown, Murdock) vs interpretive understand (Weber, Evans-Pritchard, Geertz) → **the observer** — subjectivity (Redfield–Lewis, Mead–Freeman), reflexivity, triangulation → **phenomenology** — Husserl, Merleau-Ponty; Jackson, Csordas, Stoller → **mixed methods** — convergent, explanatory, exploratory; People of India.

ESSENTIAL TERMS

technique • method • methodology • paradigm • ontology • epistemology • research design • inductive/deductive • qualitative/quantitative • emic/etic • nomothetic/idiographic • Verstehen • reflexivity • triangulation • epoché • lifeworld • embodiment • mixed methods • pragmatism

STORY HOOKS

Tepoztlán: Redfield vs Lewis • the cooking analogy • Evans-Pritchard's poison oracle • Mead vs Freeman • Stoller learning to taste • People of India: one schedule, 4,635 profiles

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Comte • Durkheim 1895 • Weber • Windelband 1894 • Husserl • Heidegger 1927 • Schutz 1932 • Murdock 1937/49 • Merleau-Ponty 1945 • Evans-Pritchard 1937/50 • Kuhn 1962 • Pelto & Pelto 1970 • Denzin 1970 • Geertz 1973 • Freeman 1983 • Jackson 1989 • Stoller 1989 • Csordas 1990 • Creswell & Plano Clark 2007 • K. S. Singh

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. Technique answers "with what?", method "how?", methodology "why, and how do we know?".
- 2. Subjectivity cannot be removed from fieldwork, only acknowledged and checked.
- 3. Anthropology bridges science and the humanities; mixed methods is the practical bridge.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 pyramid + Malinowski column • Fig. 2 explain | understand on six rows • Fig. 3 merge / quan → qual / qual → quan + four triangulations.

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- Method ≠ methodology — practice vs philosophy.
- Participant observation is a **method**; the field diary and genealogy chart are **techniques**.
- Mixed methods is not just "using two tools" — it requires integration.
- Redfield–Lewis and Mead–Freeman are about method, not about which village was "really" right.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 8) and Edukemy's 2013–2023 lists (1986–93 distinction stems; 2006 and 2007 filed there under tools); 2025 and 2026 papers. Allocation of 2006, 2007 and 2019 to 8-B is mine — they are questions about methodology.
- **Mains Value.** Your tracker's PYQ Count of 16 covers all of Topic 8; this sub-topic's count is 4 (1995–2026). High stands on the 2019 and 2026 weight.
- **Sources** — Pelto & Pelto (1970); Bernard (1988 on); Durkheim (1895); Evans-Pritchard (1937, 1950); Geertz (1973); Denzin (1970); Husserl, Schutz, Merleau-Ponty; Jackson (1989); Csordas (1990); Stoller (1989); Kleinman (1988); Creswell & Plano Clark (2007); Anthropological Survey of India on People of India.
- **The Redfield quote** about "enjoy" and "suffer" is widely reported but its exact wording varies — present it as reported. Evans-Pritchard's remark on the oracle is paraphrased.
- **People of India figures** — 4,635 communities is the standard figure; avoid quoting the number of scholars.